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Influencers enter mix in mayoral race

Social media video creators rise in importance for Johnson campaign; political posts lack regulation

By Jake Sheridan
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The 10-second post looked normal, like almost anything passing by on another mindless scroll. But as Mayor Brandon Johnson cracked a joke with a social media influencer interviewing him in front of the Chicago skyline, a tag near the caption stuck out: “Paid partnership.”

That made Johnson the first announced or likely candidate in Chicago’s next mayoral election to acknowledge paying a content creator to post a political video supporting him. The disclosure late last month marks the arrival of a new form of campaign advertising in a Chicago election. The decision by Johnson — who has not yet officially launched a 2027 mayoral bid — is

a sign the mayor believes short-video influencers on platforms like Instagram and TikTok hold rising, largely untapped sway over voters as he weighs a reelection run. It’s a strategy that raises thorny questions about compensation and disclosure but one, Johnson campaign director Christian Perry said, that will only grow more common. “Any campaign worth their salt will be trying to figure out: In the same way you pay for airtime, you pay for screen time,” Perry told the Tribune. “This is not anything nefarious, new or unsavory. This is

where people are getting their news and information.” The campaign has so far only paid for posts from one creator, according to Perry — a drop in the overflowing bucket of online discourse about the mayor. Several other content creators sharing online support for Johnson told the Tribune they had not been paid, with some adding they’ve never even had contact with his team. Still, for all candidates, it’s a largely unregulated space that opens the door to overly fawning coverage, or even misinforma-

tion. Social media platforms do little to help viewers distinguish a campaign’s unpaid supporters from its paid contractors, and some politicians have turned to influencers to get their message out without facing the scrutiny and pesky questions provided by more traditional news outlets. In Johnson’s own paid and unpaid videos with supportive creators, he does not face challenging questions — instead, he’s given largely unmitigated opportunities

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Ambar Merlin, center, walks with her son Uriel, 2, as Andrea Avila, right, carries her son Sebastian, 2, at the end of the day at Brightpoint's Mitzi Freidheim Child & Family Center on Friday. BrightPoint operates six early learning centers in the state. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Immigration weighs on Minnesota Senate race

Trump’s crackdown hangs over bruising Democratic primary

By Jonathan J. Cooper
ASSOCIATED PRESS

MINNEAPOLIS — In the streets surrounding a drab federal office complex next to the Minneapolis airport, the beleaguered resistance to President Donald Trump found its footing. As U.S. immigration agents staged at the Bishop Henry Whipple Federal Building for a monthslong deportation campaign, protesters with whistles and cellphone cameras assembled to oppose them. Over the following months, two were shot and killed in the city’s streets before Trump pulled back under pressure. Now those confrontations remain the backdrop to Minnesota’s Democratic primary for U.S. Senate on Tuesday, which features establishment-backed U.S. Rep. Angie Craig and the more progressive Lt. Gov. Peggy Flanagan.

The immigration debate is an added rift in a race that otherwise echoes many of the other left versus center divides that have played out across the United States this year. Craig voted for tighter enforcement soon after Trump returned to office last year, only to later express regret for her decision after the Republican president sent a surge of agents into Minneapolis. She backed a resolution that condemned antisemitism after a 2025 firebombing in Boulder, Colorado, and expressed thanks for law enforcement, including U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers. Those votes may turn out to be some of the most fraught of Craig’s eight-year career in Congress, decisions that Flanagan has highlighted while trying to portray her rival as unwilling to fight an unpopular administration in Washington. “I think that’s when she lost my vote permanently and that’s why I will not vote for her no matter

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Trump deregulation plan vexes Head Start providers

The proposal would drop hundreds of rules in order to streamline and expand the program and cut administrative costs

By Kate Perez
and Lila Hempel-Edgers
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Nearly a decade ago, Head Start gave Wendy Mamola and her children the footing to leave an abusive situation. The federally funded program for low-income families with infants, toddlers and preschoolers at Palatine Community Child Care Center offered her oldest son a safe place to stay during court hearings. It provided consistent

adults in his life during a time Mamola struggled with anxiety and, later, postpartum depression. In the years since, it’s connected all four of her kids with medical care and academic support. Her two oldest have aged out of the program and are thriving in public school, while her youngest, twins, are now enrolled at the Palatine center. “I wouldn’t have been able to leave their father if it wasn’t for the fact that they were enrolled there,” said Mamola, 34, who lives

in Rolling Meadows. “It made all the difference.” Now, the Trump administration is proposing sweeping changes to the early childhood program that would eliminate federal requirements for services that Head Start leaders say offer crucial support for families in need, such as Mamola’s. Last Thursday, the Department of Health and Human Services, which oversees Head Start, issued a proposed rule that would scrap 1,400 regulations and replace them with a more “streamlined framework” in an effort to reduce regulatory and administrative costs and expand the program to more families. “We are removing unnecessary bureaucracy, strengthening

nutrition and physical health, trusting parents and local communities, and opening Head Start to hundreds of thousands more children,” HHS Secretary Robert F. Kennedy, Jr. said in a statement. “That’s how we renew the promise of Head Start for the next generation.” Head Start leaders in Illinois say it’s too soon to tell how the proposed rule will fully affect the low-income families in the state, but many say they are alarmed. Classes could have more students and fewer educators under the proposal, and programs would be required to be taught in English instead of supporting dual-lan-

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INSIDE

Bally’s Chicago pauses project

The firm halted construction on nearly all non-gaming amenities at its \$1.7 billion casino complex in River West — putting 1,500 workers on hiatus — because of a stand-off with the city over video gambling. **Chicagoland, A3**

Foo Fighters dig into their past

Dave Grohl and his band surveyed 31 years of their history Saturday in a three-hour concert at Soldier Field. It was a full-circle retrospective and an old-school rock show that shunned extravagant props. **Arts & Living, B5**

Cat tours arrive, and the first is a purrfect smash

By Christopher Borrelli
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Behold! The majestic beasts of Lincoln Square! So reclusive, so elusive, so easily bored. Felis catus, a.k.a. the domestic cat. On Saturday — or Saturday, as it is now known on the North Side — this rare creature was witnessed lounging in the apartment windows of three-story walk-ups, on porches of Victorian homes, behind mesh enclosures in front yards, at the bottom of baby strollers. Hordes of observers, a thousand or so, clustered on sidewalks, here and there, many with pricey cameras, many more with cat tattoos and cat T-shirts, eager for cat sightings.

A shout rose: “There!” Fingers flew skyward immediately, as if everyone had spotted a UFO. In a window on Hamilton Avenue, the tabby known as Crumb, a real auburn cutie pie, appeared. Crumb regarded his admirers, then he yawned, then he jumped down, slipping from view again. “Amazing! A 10 out of 10!” someone said. Someone else, less impressed with such a brief sighting, quipped: “Whoa, whoa, whoa. I mean, haven’t these cats been schooled yet in the ways of PSPSPSPSPSPSPSP?” The first (and probably not the last) Lincoln Square Cat Tour prowled the streets of this

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Kat Nasser, wearing a “Pink Persian Club” shirt, shows off Gertrude during Saturday’s Lincoln Square Cat Tour. **ARTHUR MAIORELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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